



# A Cross-Party Majority, and a Procedural Back Door

Teacher copy (everything in the student copy, plus answers and teaching notes)

## The article, marked for rhetorical devices:

- 1 On Thursday the House voted 226 to 195 to send Ukraine more than \$1 billion in security and reconstruction aid and to open up to \$8 billion in defense loans [paragraph 1: statistics, logos], along with new sanctions on key parts of the Russian economy, including its energy sector. The bill passed over the stated objections of President Trump and the House's own Republican leaders.
- 2 It reached the floor at all only through a discharge petition, the rarely successful procedure that lets a majority of members force a vote when leadership refuses to schedule one. Two hundred and eighteen signatures are required. Supporters got them. [paragraph 2: short declarative, syntax] Eighteen Republicans then crossed over to join all but one Democrat, Ilhan Omar of Minnesota, who voted no.
- 3 The bill's sponsor, Representative Gregory Meeks of New York [paragraph 3: named attribution, ethos], framed the money as overdue. Representative Don Bacon of Nebraska, one of the Republicans who broke ranks, put it in starker terms on the floor: “Are we going to stand with good or are we going to stand with evil?” [paragraph 3: rhetorical question] That's what this is about tonight.” The leadership's case was quieter and procedural. [paragraph 3: concession and refutation] Majority Leader Steve Scalise argued that the administration's own negotiations were already moving, and that legislating around them could set them back: “you set that back,” he said, “if you pass legislation that doesn't go as far as the negotiations are going.”
- 4 What the House did on Thursday it cannot finish on its own. The bill goes next to the Senate, where it needs 60 votes, and where the count is not there. A companion measure on Russian tariffs and secondary sanctions has already stalled. By the arithmetic of the chamber the aid does not advance unless Trump endorses it, which he has so far declined to do.
- 5 So the vote settles less than its margin suggests. It records that a cross-party majority of one chamber wants the aid sent now, and that the same majority was willing to go around its own leadership to say so. Whether any of the money reaches Ukraine is a separate question. It belongs to the Senate, and to the president the House just voted against [paragraph 5: irony].

## Quick reference (devices used):

- Paragraph 1: statistics, logos
- Paragraph 2: short declarative, syntax
- Paragraph 3: named attribution, ethos; rhetorical question; concession and refutation
- Paragraph 5: irony

## AP-style multiple choice:

1. In the second paragraph, the brief sentence “Supporters got them.” primarily serves to
  - A) inject the writer's approval of the bill's passage
  - B) mark, without comment, that a difficult procedural threshold was met
  - C) question whether the signatures were legitimately obtained
  - D) summarize the passage's overall argument
2. The writer juxtaposes Bacon's question about “good” and “evil” with Scalise's procedural caution mainly to
  - A) ridicule Scalise's position as evasive
  - B) frame the dispute as moral conviction against procedural caution, without resolving it
  - C) prove that the bill's supporters held the stronger argument
  - D) build suspense about the final vote count

**Multiple choice answer key:**

1. **Answer B.** The clipped sentence (syntax) states that 218 signatures were reached and leaves it there, the impartial habit of the piece.
2. **Answer B.** The neutral juxtaposition sets a pathos-driven appeal beside a procedural one and leaves the reader to weigh them.

**Discussion questions:**

1. The writer never says whether the aid is a good idea. How does the passage still leave you with an impression of where the weight of the argument falls, and through what choices?
2. Why might a writer reporting a politically charged vote choose to end on procedure (“it belongs to the Senate”) rather than on either side's strongest line?

**Sample strong discussion responses:**

1. A strong answer notes the piece never editorializes but stacks choices that tilt it: it gives Bacon's vivid moral line more room than Scalise's procedural caution, ends on the aid stalling, and frames the holdouts as going 'around its own leadership.' The lean is built from arrangement and emphasis, not from stated opinion.
2. Ending on the Senate and the president keeps the register impartial: it reports the state of play rather than rooting for an outcome, and it quietly lands the irony that the aid now depends on the very president the House just defied.

**Writing prompt (homework or extended in-class, Q3 argument):**

The passage describes a chamber registering a position it may lack the power to enact. Defend, challenge, or qualify the claim that a symbolic vote a legislature cannot turn into law is still a meaningful political act. Use your own knowledge, observation, or reading.

**Common misconceptions to watch for:**

- Students may call the dollar figures 'pathos' because the topic feels emotional. The numbers are logos: evidence to be weighed, not feeling.
- Students may read the Bacon quote as the writer's own view. It is attributed; the writer reports it, and balances it against the leadership's case.
- 'Concession' is not the same as 'both sides.' Here the leadership's case is granted, then refuted by the close.

**AP exam alignment:**

Q2 rhetorical-analysis value: a compact study of how attribution, the juxtaposition of opposing sources, and sentence length build an impartial ethos. Useful for teaching that tone is constructed by arrangement, not only by word choice.